

## Pedro Magaña Sáenz

Agricultural and Applied Economics, University of Wisconsin-Madison

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### Education

University of Wisconsin—Madison | Wisconsin, United States

*Ph.D. in Agricultural and Applied Economics*

*May 2026 (expected)*

University of Michigan—Ann Arbor | Michigan, United States

*M.S. in Applied Economics*

*2019*

*M.A. in Public Policy*

*2019*

Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM) | Mexico City, Mexico

*B.A. in Economics*

*2012*

### Fields of Interest

Development Economics; Agricultural Economics; Organizational Economics; Firms; Public Policy

### Citizenship and U.S. work authorization

Mexican citizen with U.S. permanent residency

### Working papers

**Signed, Sealed, Delivered: Digital Receipts in the Ugandan Dairy Chain (Job Market Paper)**

*with David J. Henning*

Using a randomized experiment with dairy cooperatives in western Uganda, we provide causal evidence that SMS-based digital receipts for daily milk deliveries improve accountability, product quality, and delivery frequency. In a context of weak monitoring and imperfect transaction information, these messages allow smallholder farmers to better observe the behavior of intermediaries in the supply chain. The intervention effects vary with the intensity of information frictions. Among farmers facing high information frictions (i.e., those relying on intermediaries to transport milk), the intervention increased the detection of discrepancies and encouraged switching away from dishonest intermediaries. Farmers in low-friction settings (those who deliver milk themselves) delivered more frequently; the likely mechanism is a behavioral nudge created by receiving messages both on days with deliveries and days without deliveries. We also find that the intervention increased milk quality for both self-deliverers and farmers using transporters. Overall, our results show that simple digital tools can reduce information asymmetries and strengthen accountability in smallholder supply chains.

*Coverage:* World Bank Development Impact Blog

### Work in progress

**Banking Amidst Conflict: How Violence Shapes Financial Inclusion in Mexico**

*with Xiaofei Wang*

**Digital Monitoring and Quality-Contingent Contracts: Aligning Incentives in the Ugandan Dairy Sector**

*with Taesoo Choi*

**Silent Transfers: Violence and Income Reporting in Mexico**

**From Prayer to Progress: Religious Festivals and Development in Mexico**

## Research Grants

|                                                                                              |      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| PEDL CEPR – Exploratory Research Grant, £40,000 GBP                                          | 2026 |
| Role: <b>PI</b> – with Taesoo Choi                                                           |      |
| The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD   | 2025 |
| Role: <b>PI</b> – with David J. Henning and Erick Molina Perez                               |      |
| International Growth Centre (IGC) – Agri-SME Evidence Fund, £20,000 GBP                      | 2024 |
| Role: <b>PI</b> – with David J. Henning                                                      |      |
| The Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics – University of Chicago, \$15,000 USD   | 2023 |
| Role: <b>PI</b> – with David J. Henning                                                      |      |
| J-PAL/CEGA – Digital Agricultural Innovations and Services (DAISI) Initiative , \$71,000 USD | 2023 |
| Role: <b>PI</b> – with David J. Henning                                                      |      |
| International Growth Centre (IGC) – Small Project Facility, £20,000 GBP                      | 2022 |
| Role: <b>PI</b> – with David J. Henning                                                      |      |
| <b>Total external funding raised as PI: \$206,000 USD</b>                                    |      |

## Honors and Awards

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|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| AAE Conference Presentation Award (x2) – University of Wisconsin—Madison, \$1,600 USD               | 2025        |
| AAEA Travel Grant – Agricultural & Applied Economics Association (AAEA)                             | 2025        |
| Thomsen Distinguished Graduate Dissertator Fellowship (nominated) – University of Wisconsin—Madison | 2024        |
| AAE Dissertator Research Award – University of Wisconsin—Madison, \$1,000 USD                       | 2024        |
| Barbara and Thomas Lyon Scholarship, \$4,000 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison.                  | 2023        |
| UW-Madison Travel Grant, \$1,500 USD, University of Wisconsin—Madison                               | 2022        |
| Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award, University of Wisconsin—Madison                               | 2021 – 2022 |
| Rackham International Student Fellowship, \$10,000 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor.           | 2019        |
| Annenberg Internship, \$7,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor                                 | 2017        |
| Ford School Fellowship, \$2,500 USD, University of Michigan—Ann Arbor                               | 2017        |

## Research Experience

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|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| Research Assistant, University of Wisconsin   Madison, Wisconsin                                    |                |
| Professors: Dr. Dustin Frye, Dr. Corbett Grainger, and Dr. Bradford Barham                          | 2021 – Present |
| Research Assistant, University of Michigan   Ann Arbor, Michigan                                    |                |
| Professors: Dr. Eduardo Montero and Dr. Zach Y. Brown                                               | Spring 2020    |
| Research Assistant, Center on Finance, Law and Policy, University of Michigan   Ann Arbor, Michigan |                |
| Professors: Michael Barr, J.D.; Dr. Antoinette Schoar, and Dr. Eldar Shafir                         | Fall 2019      |
| Research Assistant, Northwestern University   Chicago, Illinois                                     |                |
| Professors: Dr. Erika Deserranno and Dr. Gianmarco Leon-Ciliotta                                    | Summer 2019    |
| Research Associate, University of Michigan   Ann Arbor, Michigan                                    |                |
| Economic Growth Institute                                                                           | 2018 – 2019    |
| Research Assistant, University of Michigan   Ann Arbor, Michigan                                    |                |
| Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg                                | 2017 – 2018    |
| Country Office Intern, Innovations for Poverty Action   Lilongwe, Malawi                            |                |
| Professors: Dr. Dean Yang; Dr. Xavier Giné, and Dr. Jessica Goldberg                                | Summer 2017    |
| Research Coordinator, Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM)   Mexico City, Mexico         |                |
| Professors: Dr. Enrique Seira and Dr. Joyce Sadka                                                   | 2011 – 2012    |

## Professional Experience

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|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Economic Analysis Coordinator, Ministry of Finance   Mexico City, Mexico     | 2014 – 2016 |
| Market Analyst, Laureate International Universities   Mexico City, Mexico    | 2013 – 2014 |
| Financial Analyst, Laureate International Universities   Mexico City, Mexico | 2012 – 2013 |
| Parliamentary Advisor, Senate of Mexico   Mexico City, Mexico                | 2010 – 2011 |

## Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, University of Wisconsin | Madison, Wisconsin

*AAE 474/ECON 474: Economic Problems of Developing Areas*

*AAE 350: World Hunger and Malnutrition*

*MATH 221: Calculus and Analytic Geometry II*

*Fall 2025*

*Spring 2022*

*Fall 2020*

Teaching Assistant, University of Michigan | Ann Arbor, Michigan

*PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation*

*POLSCI 369: International Economic Relations*

*PUBPOL 639: Quantitative Methods for Program Evaluation*

*POLSCI 490: Game Theory and Formal Models*

*Spring 2019*

*Fall 2018*

*Spring 2018*

*Fall 2017*

## Pre-Doctoral Publications

**Magaña Sáenz, P.F.** (2015). Behavioral Economics and Nudges Applied to Pawnshops. **Gaceta de Economía**, 34, 96-126. (Original in Spanish)

## Talks

2026 PacDev 2026 (University of California, Davis), CSAE 2026 (University of Oxford), MEA 2026

2025 AFE 2025 (University of Chicago), World Bank–KDI School Development Impact Conference, AAEA/WAEA Joint Annual Meeting, 2025 WEFIDEV-RFS-CEPR Conference (LSE), Juli Plant Grainger Public Workshop, Applied Economics Workshop (University of Wisconsin)

2024 Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)

2023 Development Workshop, Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)

2022 Development Lab, Student Research Colloquium (University of Wisconsin)

2021 Development Lab (University of Wisconsin)

## Affiliations

Graduate Research Fellow, Institute for Research on Poverty, University of Wisconsin

2025 – 2026

## Other Information

Languages: Spanish (Native), English (Fluent)

Skills: Stata (Advanced), L<sup>A</sup>T<sub>E</sub>X (Advanced), Microsoft Office (Advanced), R (Intermediate), Python (Intermediate)

## References

Laura Schechter  
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